

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN CONFRONT ENVIRONMENTAL HARM AND DESTRUCTIVE PROJECTS IN MARTINIQUE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Martinique's distinctive ground — confronting the chlordécone poison and defending health, land, and sea through the French and European legal systems, the EU frameworks, and a powerful civic movement — and it names the tools you'll meet (health recognition and compensation, decontamination science, the French and EU courts and human-rights channels, food-safety monitoring, the EIA and public inquiry) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Martinique's environmental reality begins with a **poison in the soil**. **Chlordécone** — a banana-plantation pesticide — was used here for **two decades after its dangers were known**, and it has **contaminated the land for generations**, tainted the rivers and the sea, restricted the fisheries, and left its trace in the **blood of almost the entire population**. It is a persistent poison that will outlast everyone now living. Against it, Martinicans have built a long, painful, and still-unfinished struggle for recognition, protection, and accountability — a powerful civic movement, affected families, scientists, and their legal allies pressing through the French and European systems. That struggle has won real things: **health recognitions** (including the acknowledgment of chlordécone-linked illness as an occupational disease), decontamination science, food-safety monitoring, and a national reckoning that a poisoning had occurred. But it has also met the hard wall of a contamination that cannot be removed and a criminal accountability that, after twenty years, the courts **denied**. This is the ground Martinicans stand on — and, this guide will show, it is ground on which real, if partial, victories can be won.

The Martinican movement against the chlordécone legacy — affected families, scientists, and their legal allies — draws on a toolkit strengthened by the French and European frameworks, in a rule-of-law European territory. **Health recognition and compensation** channels exist for those harmed, including the acknowledgment of chlordécone-linked illness as an occupational disease. **Food-safety standards and monitoring** can be invoked to force testing and limits on what reaches the market. The **French and European courts**, the **EU frameworks**, and **human-rights channels** are genuinely powerful. A new project needs an **EIA and public inquiry (enquête publique)**, open to challenge. And a **powerful civic movement**, a free press, and democratic protest carry it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The **contamination is effectively permanent** — it will outlast generations, and the poison cannot be removed from the soil. The **criminal accountability has, after twenty years, been denied** in the courts — the case dismissed, acknowledgment without full justice. The **banana monoculture endures** and the economy depends on it. The **sargassum tides** return each year to foul the coasts. And a **colonial history and an economic dependency** run through the whole struggle, shaping who was poisoned, who profited, and whose justice was deferred. So this guide does not pretend the poison can be removed, or that the courts have delivered criminal justice; what it shows is how, through these genuinely powerful channels, Martinicans can confront the legacy, protect health and food, and defend the land and sea — winning the real, partial victories that recognition, protection, and vigilance make possible.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A permanent poison, and the projects and pressures that compound it, look like harms too vast to fight — but each has a channel that reaches it. The chlordécone legacy is confronted through **health recognition, decontamination science, and the legal and EU channels**; the land and food through **agroecology and food-safety monitoring**; the sea and sargassum through **management and the law**; a new destructive project through the **EIA, the public inquiry, and the courts**. Every one of those is a lever you can pull. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If you or your family were harmed by chlordécone, the health-recognition and compensation channels are a real, winnable lever** — recognition has been secured.
- **If the land and food are contaminated, decontamination science and food-safety monitoring protect what can be protected.**
- **If a new project threatens, the EIA, the public inquiry, and the French and EU courts are genuinely powerful.**
- **If you seek criminal justice for the poisoning, be honest that the courts have denied it** — press the political, memorial, and reparative struggle, and the health and civil channels, where wins are still real.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **confront the poison and defend health, land, and sea through the genuinely powerful French, EU, and movement channels**, and **hold both truths** — that the poison is permanent and criminal justice denied, and that real, partial victories of recognition, protection, and defence are genuinely winnable. That's the Martinican struggle.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, and where you jump in.

Who Actually Decides

Martinique is an **overseas department of France and part of the EU**, so decisions run through the **French state and its agencies** (health, agriculture, environment), the **French and European courts**, and the **EU frameworks**. **Health-recognition and compensation** bodies handle those harmed. **Food-safety and decontamination** agencies monitor the poison. A new project needs an **EIA and public inquiry** and permits. And **human-rights channels** (French and European) and a **powerful civic movement** press the whole. Know which channel — health, food, courts, EU, project — reaches your harm, and aim there.

How the Harm — and a Project — Moves, and Where You Jump In

The chlordécone legacy. *Your opening:* the **health-recognition and compensation** channel for those harmed; the **decontamination and food-safety** channels for the land and food; the **courts, EU, and human-rights** channels for accountability and protection.

A new project. It needs an **EIA and public inquiry**. *Your opening:* take part in the **enquête publique**, object, and challenge a defective assessment in the **French and EU courts**.

The land, sea, and coast. *Your opening:* agroecology and food-safety for the land; management and the law for the sargassum and sea; the planning and heritage channels for the coast.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who caused or profits from the harm** — the monoculture, the polluters, the developers — and where the colonial and dependency dynamic runs. **What channel reaches your harm** — health recognition, food safety, the courts, the EU, the EIA. **What a new project still needs** — the EIA, the inquiry, the permit: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **French health, food-safety, and environmental agencies** monitor and recognise. The **French and European courts** and the **EU frameworks** enforce rights and standards. **Human-rights channels** press accountability. And Martinique's **powerful civic movement, affected families, scientists, and a free press** are the forces that reach furthest — the movement that forced the national reckoning.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: which channel reaches your harm, and whether it's a winnable (health, food, protection) or a denied (criminal accountability) fight.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents/evidence	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Health recognition / compensation claim	30–55%	months–yr	low	Harm recognised; compensation
Food-safety monitoring / decontamination science	30–55%	ongoing	low	Exposure reduced; food protected
EIA / public inquiry objection (new project)	20–45%	during inquiry	low	Conditions; a redo; refusal
French / EU court challenge	30–55%	1–3 yr	mod	Project quashed; rights enforced
Human-rights channels	25–50%	years	low	Accountability pressed; recognition
Criminal accountability (the poisoning)	low	years	high	Denied by the courts, honestly
Civic movement + press	(enabling)	ongoing	low	The reckoning forced; pressure sustained
Everything together (health/food/protection channels + movement)	40–65%	years	mod	Recognition, protection, a project stopped
Everything together (criminal accountability sought)	low	years	high	Acknowledgment without full justice

The levers that move the needle most are the **health-recognition, food-safety, and legal/EU channels**, and a **new project's EIA and courts**, all carried by a **powerful civic movement**. The chlórdécone struggle shows the ceiling (recognition, protection, a national reckoning) and the honest floor (the poison permanent,

criminal justice denied). So aim for harm recognised and compensated, food and land protected, a new project stopped, and the reckoning advanced — and hold both truths.

On cost: the health, food, and civic channels are low-cost and genuinely usable; court challenges cost more but the French and EU systems are real; the strength is a powerful movement and genuine rights, not money. The great requirement is to hold both truths — that the poison is permanent and criminal justice denied, and that real, partial victories are still there to be won.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the harm" in general is weak. Being specific — this health claim, this contaminated field, this new project's EIA — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

- 1. What is the harm, and who caused or profits from it?** Name it — a health harm, a contaminated field, a restricted fishery, a new project — and the monoculture, polluter, or developer behind it.
- 2. What does it touch, and whom?** Map it over **health, the land and food, the rivers and sea, the coast.** The chlórdécone harm to health, land, and food is the central ground.
- 3. Which channel reaches it?** Health recognition and compensation? Food-safety and decontamination? The EIA and courts (new project)? The EU and human-rights channels? Pick the channel that reaches your harm.
- 4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is a health claim open? A public inquiry running? A court window? A monitoring cycle? These openings are time-bound.
- 5. Who's your coalition?** The powerful civic movement, affected families, scientists, and legal and EU allies. The chlórdécone reckoning was forced by that movement.

What this looks like in real life. A family's illness, a poisoned field, or a new polluting project meets the chlórdécone-shaped landscape. The five questions yield: a harm and its cause; health, land, or a project at stake; the channel that reaches it (health recognition, food safety, the courts); an open deadline; and the civic movement. That's the Martinican pattern — pick the channel that reaches your harm, and press it with the movement, holding both truths.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can confront the harm and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the harm and the channel. Document your specific harm — the **health record** (for a recognition or compensation claim), the **contamination data** (for a field or fishery), the **EIA and inquiry record** (for a new project) — and identify the channel that reaches it. Use French and EU **information rights** to obtain what's held.

Layer two: the science. Marshal the **science** — the chlórdécone contamination and health data, the decontamination and food-safety evidence, the environmental assessment of a new project. In a rule-of-law European territory, credible science is what the health, food, and court channels act on.

Layer three: the map of harm and channel. Lay the harm over the land, water, and people, and match it to the channel that reaches it, so the case is undeniable and correctly aimed. Walking into the health, food,

court, or EU channel with the harm documented, the science, and the right channel identified is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **Your specific harm** — the health record, the contamination data, or the EIA/inquiry record — via French and EU information rights.
- **The science** — chlordécone contamination and health, decontamination, food safety, the project's assessment.
- **The channel** — health recognition, food safety, the courts, the EU, the EIA — that reaches your harm.
- **The harm-and-channel map** — the harm over land, water, and people, matched to its channel.
- **Named testimony** — of affected families and those who know the land and sea.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a powerful civic movement gives you power — the Martinican model. Build in four moves.

Join the powerful civic movement. Martinique's chlordécone reckoning was forced by a **powerful civic movement** of affected families, scientists, unions, and citizens. Join and build it — it is the force that carried the struggle to a national reckoning and can carry your fight.

Match your harm to its channel. The movement's strength is knowing which channel reaches which harm — health recognition for the sick, food safety for the land, the courts and EU for accountability and new projects. Aim your energy at the channel that reaches your harm.

Bring in the scientists and legal allies. In a rule-of-law European territory, the struggle runs on **credible science and legal and EU expertise**. Reach the scientists who document the harm and the lawyers who know the French and EU systems and human-rights channels.

Build to last, and hold both truths. The chlordécone struggle is generational. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the long toll — and the resolve to **hold both truths**: that the poison is permanent and criminal justice denied, and that real, partial victories of recognition, protection, and defence are still winnable.

STEP 4: LEGAL, HEALTH & EU CHANNELS

Martinique's sharpest levers are the health-recognition, legal, and EU channels a European territory affords, carried by the movement.

Health Recognition and Compensation — a Winnable Lever

For those harmed by chlordécone, the **health-recognition and compensation** channels are real and winnable — recognition of chlordécone-linked illness (including as an occupational disease) has been secured. Pursue the claim, with medical and scientific evidence, for those affected.

Decontamination, Food Safety, and the Land

Protect what can be protected: **food-safety monitoring** to keep contaminated food from tables, **decontamination science** and **agroecology** to manage and reduce exposure on the land, and the fisheries

protections around the poisoned waters. The poison is permanent, but exposure can be reduced.

The Courts, the EU, and Human-Rights Channels

Use the **French and European courts**, the **EU frameworks**, and **human-rights channels** to enforce rights, protect health and environment, and press accountability — and, for a **new project**, to challenge a defective **EIA** or a flawed **public inquiry**. These are genuinely powerful in a rule-of-law European territory.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the health, food, legal, and EU channels are real and usable, but the **contamination is permanent**, the **criminal accountability has been denied** by the courts, the **monoculture endures**, and a **colonial dynamic** runs through it all. So use the strong channels — health recognition, food safety, the courts, the EU, human rights — carried by the movement, hold both truths, and count harm recognised and compensated, food and land protected, a new project stopped, and the reckoning advanced as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Illness becomes a recognised harm. Not "we were poisoned" but *"this illness is chlordécone-linked, and the recognition and compensation channels must acknowledge it,"* as recognition has been won.

Contamination becomes a protection duty. *"This food and land carry chlordécone — food-safety monitoring and decontamination must protect us."*

A new project becomes a legal challenge. *"The EIA and public inquiry were defective — the French and EU courts can quash the permit."*

The poisoning becomes a reckoning. *"A poison used for two decades after its dangers were known, in the blood of almost the whole population — acknowledgment is not yet full justice."*

Match it to the venue: the illness to the health-recognition channel; the contamination to food-safety and decontamination; the new project to the EIA, inquiry, and courts; the reckoning to the political, memorial, and human-rights struggle.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Martinique, the reckoning with the poison and the power of the civic movement are the levers — a struggle over a poison in the blood of a whole people commands national and international attention. A free press makes the media front central.

Lead with the poison and the people, not procedure. Not "the recognition criteria are unmet" but "a poison used for two decades after its dangers were known, in the blood of almost every Martinican — and a people still fighting for recognition and justice." Use your strongest material: the science, the affected families' stories, and any recognition or court progress banked.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national (French) press carry the reckoning and reach the state; European and international attention reach the EU and human-rights channels; the science and the human story move everyone. Make it easy: clear summaries, strong testimony, careful science.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything, especially on the health and contamination science. And centre the affected families and the movement, and hold both truths in the story — the permanent poison and the real, partial victories.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to a French/EU agency).

Subject: Request for records — [harm/project].

"We, [residents/families] of [place], request the [health, contamination, or EIA/inquiry] records for [harm/project] at [location], under our information rights. [Contact.]"

8B — Health recognition / compensation claim.

Subject: Chlordécone-linked harm — recognition and compensation.

"I/we seek recognition and compensation for [chlordécone-linked illness/harm]: [the medical and scientific evidence]. We ask the [recognition/compensation body] to acknowledge it. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Food-safety / decontamination (to the agency).

Subject: Contamination and protection — [land/food/fishery].

"We, [residents] of [place], report chlordécone contamination of [land/food/fishery], and ask for monitoring, decontamination, and protection: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Objection in the EIA / public inquiry (new project).

Subject: Objection — [project] enquête publique.

"We, [residents] of [place], object to [project]: [it harms health/land/sea; the EIA is defective]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a lawyer (French/EU courts, human rights).

Subject: Legal challenge — [harm/project].

"We face [the harm/project], and seek to [enforce our rights / challenge the permit / press accountability] through the French and EU courts and human-rights channels. We've gathered [the evidence]. We ask your advice. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the responsible party / developer.

Subject: Harm, legal, and reputational risk — [harm/project].

"We are the community affected by [harm/project] at [location]. It causes [the harm], and faces legal challenge and the movement's pressure. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press (Martinican, French, international).

Subject: [Community] confronts [the chlordécone harm / project].

"Our [health, land, sea] bears [the chlordécone poison / this project]. We can provide the science, the families' stories, and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the movement.

Subject: We can win recognition and protection — here's how.

"[The harm] endures, and the criminal courts have denied us justice. But the movement has won recognition, protection, and a national reckoning — and those victories are still there to be won. If we press the channels that reach our harm and hold together, we can win them. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Identify your specific harm and the channel that reaches it — health, food, courts, EU, EIA.**
2. **Document the harm and the science (8A), and pursue the right claim (8B/8C/8D).**
3. **For a new project, object in the public inquiry (8D).**
4. **Get legal help for the French/EU courts and human-rights channels (8E).**
5. **Join and build the civic movement (8H), and reach the press (8G).**
6. **Hold both truths — the permanent poison, and the real, partial victories still winnable.**

Even lean, those six pick the channel that reaches your harm and press it with the movement — the Martinican template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Martinique's channels are real, but a colonial and dependency dynamic tilts the ground, and you must plan for it.

When criminal justice is denied. The courts dismissed the criminal case. Press instead the health, civil, political, memorial, and human-rights channels, where recognition and protection are still winnable.

When the poison is permanent. It cannot be removed. Aim at reducing exposure — food safety, decontamination, agroecology — and at recognition and protection, not at an impossible cleanup.

When the monoculture and dependency endure. The economy leans on the banana. Press agroecology and food safety, and name the colonial and dependency dynamic honestly, without pretending the monoculture will vanish.

When a new project threatens. Use the genuinely powerful EIA, public inquiry, and French/EU courts — the rule-of-law channels a European territory affords.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Martinique's chlordécone catastrophe was itself a failure of a state and industry that used a poison after its dangers were known, so this matters.

How to spot it. A harm known and permitted anyway; recognition or protection withheld; a new project's EIA written for the proponent; the interests of the monoculture placed above health.

Who's supposed to guard against it. French **audit and public-health bodies**, the **French and European courts**, **EU frameworks**, and **human-rights bodies** provide checks. And Martinique's **civic movement, scientists, and press** have forced the reckoning and exposed the failures.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the harm known and permitted, who profited, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and public-health bodies, the courts, the EU and human-rights channels, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the recognition and protection channels.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, over the long haul. The documents and the science build your case; the right channel reaches your harm; the civic movement is the muscle; the health, food, court, and EU channels press it; the press carries the reckoning. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and hold both truths throughout.

Early on (weeks–months): identify the harm and its channel; document it and the science; pursue the health, food, or inquiry claim; join the movement.

In the thick of it (months–years): press the recognition, food-safety, or court challenge; use the French/EU and human-rights channels; open the media front.

The long haul (years–generation): carry the recognition, protection, and legal struggles; sustain the movement; hold the line for harm recognised and compensated, food and land protected, a new project stopped, and the reckoning advanced — holding both truths.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Confronting environmental harm in Martinique can be done — a powerful civic movement forced a national reckoning with a poison in the blood of almost a whole people, and won recognition and protection through the channels a European territory affords. Hold both truths. Martinique's distinctive power is real: in a rule-of-law European territory, the chlordécone legacy can be confronted, and health, land, and sea defended, through genuinely powerful channels — health recognition and compensation, decontamination and food-safety science, the French and European courts, the EU frameworks, human-rights channels, and a powerful civic movement. And the constraints are real: the contamination is permanent, the criminal accountability has been denied by the courts, the monoculture endures, the sargassum returns, and a colonial and dependency dynamic runs through it all.

Here's the discipline that wins. Identify your specific harm — an illness, a contaminated field, a new project — and match it to the channel that reaches it: health recognition and compensation for the sick, food-safety monitoring and decontamination for the land and food, the French and EU courts and the public inquiry for a new project, and the human-rights and political channels for accountability. Document it with credible science, join and build the powerful civic movement, and press the channel that reaches your harm. And

above all, hold both truths — that the poison is permanent and criminal justice denied, and that real, partial victories of recognition, protection, and defence are genuinely winnable — because a struggle that grasps both fights wisely and lasts. Count harm recognised and compensated, food and land protected, a new project stopped, and the reckoning advanced as wins. That is how Martinique's movement has fought the poison in its soil — the recognition, the protection, the law, and the movement together. So can you.